Houseplant care basics

Most houseplants die from too much water, not too little. Push a finger into the soil: if the top inch is dry, water thoroughly until it drains out the bottom, and empty the saucer.

Match the plant to the light in your room. Succulents and herbs want a bright south-facing window. Pothos, snake plants and ZZ plants cope with dim corners. Leaves that stretch toward the window or turn pale usually mean the plant needs more light.

Repot in spring when roots circle the pot or poke out of the drainage holes, moving up only one pot size. Feed with diluted fertiliser once a month while the plant is growing, and not at all in winter.